

make a career as a lawyer and were not especially pleased when, from an early age, he displayed an exceptional gift for music. After his talent on the organ was noticed by a local nobleman, the parents were persuaded to pay for music lessons with the organist at their parish church, the Marienkirche. Apart from this induction, Handel was self-taught, learning through imitating other people's compositions.

Handel was a young man of robust temperament—sociable, energetic, enterprising, gifted, with boundless self-confidence. At 18, he left Halle for the port city of Hamburg, where he was employed as an instrumentalist at the city's opera house, the Gänsemarkt theater. According to a famous anecdote, his life nearly ended there when a quarrel with a colleague led to a duel in which the point of his opponent's sword was parried only by a button on Handel's coat.



*Almira*, 2014

Handel's first opera, *Almira*, premiered in Hamburg, Germany, in 1705. The